The Politics-Media-Politics Principle: Towards a more Comprehensive Approach to Political Communication

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Abstract

This paper develops a theoretical framework labeled the Politics-Media-Politics (PMP) principle. The aim of this principle is to provide a conceptual foundation upon which to create a more comprehensive approach to explaining the role of the news media in political processes. The PMP principle is based on two central claims. First, the role of the media in political processes can best be understood as a cycle in which variations in the political environment lead to variations in media conduct that, in turn, lead to further variations in the political environment. Second, the media can play an independent role in political processes due to their ability to transform political realities into news stories that can at times have a significant impact on political outcomes. The discussion is divided into three main sections. The first section reviews some of the major theories in political communication that serve as building blocks for the PMP principle. The second section uses findings from a diverse range of studies to demonstrate the PMP principle's usefulness. The third part of the paper presents some revealing exceptions to the PMP principle.

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There is a need in the field of political communication for theories that more comprehensively explain how the role of the news media in political processes varies with time and changing circumstances. Such theories should attempt to meet four basic conditions. The first condition is that they integrate both political and media variables into one theoretical framework. With a few exceptions, most research in the field can be divided into two groups. One set of scholars primarily emphasizes the impact that political variables have on the news media. The second group focusses more on media variables and tends to either ignore or downplay political variations. Unsurprisingly, most of the first set of scholars is made up of political scientists and the second group is largely comprised of communication researchers.

The second and third requirement for a more comprehensive theory is that it explains the impact for both cross-national and cross-temporal variations on the role of the news media. Only research that examines how the role of the media varies among different cultures and throughout different historical periods can prevent us from drawing conclusions that are confined to a particular place and time.

The fourth condition may prove to be the most difficult. Ideally, the theory should be able to generate testable hypotheses across different topic areas. It should be able to identify some common themes, whether the area of study is the role of the media in wars, elections, or changes in opinion and policies concerning social issues, for example. This does not alleviate the need to also develop specific theories about particular topics, but it would be extremely helpful to develop central principles that remain relatively constant.

This paper develops and demonstrates a theoretical approach that intends is designed to move closer to meeting these conditions. It is labeled the Politics-Media-Politics (PMP) principle (Wolfsfeld, 2004, 2011). The PMP principle is based on two central claims. The first claim is that the role of the media in political processes can best be understood as a cycle in which variations in the political environment lead to variations in media conduct that, in turn, lead to further variations in the political environment. Second, the media can play an

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independent role in political processes due to their ability to transform political realities into news stories that can, at times, have a significant impact.

The purpose of this paper is to outline the basic elements of the PMP principle and provide some examples to demonstrate its utility. The ultimate aim is to show the potential of the PMP principle to serve as a suitable foundation for a more comprehensive theory. The present paper will focus on the role of the traditional media, while future work will apply the principle to the role of the new media in politics (see for example: Wolfsfeld, Segev, & Sheafer, 2013).

The discussion is divided into three major sections. The first section briefly reviews some of the major theories in political communication that serve as building blocks for the PMP principle. The second section elaborates on the PMP principle using research findings from a number of diverse areas to demonstrate its usefulness. The third and final part of the paper deals with some revealing exceptions to the PMP principle. Examining these exceptions provides important insights about how to develop a more nuanced and dynamic theory in the future.

Some Theoretical Building Blocks

The theoretical discussion begins by considering some of the main theories that help us understand the significant impact that varying political contexts can have on the role of the media. These theories provide a helpful base for the first claim about how variations in the political environment lead to variations in media conduct. A good place to start is Bennett's indexing hypothesis (1990). Bennett's central thesis was that the news is "indexed" to the range of debate in government discourse. Bennett claimed that the greater the level of elite consensus, the smaller the range of debate in the news media. While later versions of this theory (Bennett, Lawrence, & Livingston, 2006; Livingston & Bennett, 2003) attributed more autonomy to journalists, the overall thrust of this approach continued to emphasize both the ability of the government to dominate media discourse and how the mainstream media reacted to changes in political consensus.

A similar point can be made about Entman's Cascade model (Entman, 2004, 2003). Entman has investigated the ability of U.S. governments to successfully promote their ideological frames to the news media, specifically in the area of

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foreign policy. The cascade of information and interpretation normally begins with the White House, moves down through other elite individuals such as members of Congress, then to the media, which construct news frames, and finally to the public. As Entman (2003) put it: "each level in this metaphorical cascade makes its own contribution to the mix and flow (of ideas) but the ability to promote the spread of frames is also highly stratified, both across and within each level" (p. 420). As with all waterfalls, Entman argues, it is easier to go down than to go up.

Three major elements from Entman's will be helpful as the discussion moves forward. The first is that Entman's model is clearly a "politics first" model because most framing processes begin with the political elite. Second, Entman (2003) talks about the critical importance of what he calls "cultural congruence" as follows: "The more congruent the frame with schemas that dominate political culture, the more success it will enjoy" (p. 422). This reiterates the importance of considering the overall political environment before attempting to look at how the media reacts to the various frames being promoted.

The final element in the Cascade model that will prove helpful is that Entman recognizes that the media have the power to modify official frames and that certain elite journalists can have a significant impact on policy. Thus, while Entman's model places a great deal of emphasis on both political power and political context, he argues that the media should not be seen as passively passing on what officials have to say to the public. Althaus (2003) also made the case for greater press independence than that suggested by the indexing hypothesis. Studying the evening television news broadcasts covering the 1990-91 Gulf War, Althaus found that journalists used a significant amount of discretion when locating and airing oppositional views.

My own "political contest model" (Wolfsfeld, 1997) also falls firmly within the "politics first" approach. The overall thrust of this model is that researchers cannot understand the contest over the news media without first considering the overall political environment in which the contest occurs. I also argued that "the political process is more likely to have an influence on the news media than the news media are on the political process" (p. 3). One of the key elements in that

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model had to do with the authorities' level of control over the political environment. I argued that political and military leaders who were able to take control over events, regulate the flow of information, and maintain a high level of support in favor of their policies would have be relatively successful at taking control of the news media. The model also talked about the impact of journalists' professional culture on the construction of media frames; however, as with the other models mentioned here, this dimension was not a central element in the overall approach.

An additional research tradition that emphasizes the importance of context is the social construction of news approach (Adoni and Mane, 1984; Carragee & Roefs, 2006; Gamson et al., 1992; Gamson & Modigliani, 1989; Hansen, 1991; Potter & Kappeler, 2006; Schudson, 2011, 1997, 1989; Tuchman, 1978; Van Gorp, 2007). While not all advocates of this approach use the term "construction", they do agree that every news story is rooted in a particular cultural context (Fiss & Hersh, 2005; Schudson, 1996, 2011). Researchers who adopt this approach will often compare news coverage of the same event from different countries (for example, Ayish, 2002; De Vreese & Semetko, 2001; De Vreese et al., 2006; Dimitrova et al., 2005; Nossek, 2004; Yang, 2003) or changes in the coverage of social issues that take place over time (for example, Baumgartner, De Boef, and Boydstun, 2008; Bradley, 2004; Brodie et. al., 2004; Fiss & Hirsh, 2005; Gamson & Modigliani, 1989; Kellstedt, 2003). Here again, the media are seen as *responding* to variations in the political or social environment. Many of those who can be considered constructionists are based in sociology but many of the issues they deal with are political.

Constructionism is clearly an important foundation for any attempts to build a more comprehensive theory in political communication. It is essential for understanding how cross-cultural and cross-temporal variations influence the role of the news media in political processes. A good example would be to think about how the news media cover the issue of human rights and the impact that such coverage can have on public opinion and policy. Cultural assumptions and norms about the importance and meaning of the term "human rights" provide an essential starting point for any attempt to understand news coverage. Thinking

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about news as a social construction is also an excellent way to integrate the notion of news frames into this discussion. Events associated with human rights will be framed differently in various countries and in different historical periods.

The final theoretical approach that heavily emphasizes political context can be found in Hallin and Mincini's (2004) seminal work on media systems. While it is difficult to summarize this model, the central thesis is that media-politics relations can best be understand by looking at three ideal types of political systems, three ideal types of media systems, and the relationship between them. The three types of political/media systems are the Mediterranean or Polarized Pluralist model, the North/Central Europe or Democratic Corporatist model, and the North Atlantic or Liberal model.

Hallin and Mincini's (2004) approach makes a concerted effort to meet three of criteria discussed for moving towards a more comprehensive theory. First, it integrates both political and media variables into the same model. Second, the authors take a highly comparative approach to the issue and the cross-national perspective is central to their entire approach. Finally, they make it clear that there are historic explanations for how the various media systems develop.

However, one could argue that the major benefit of this important contribution also tells us something about what is lacking. The emphasis on the relationship between political and media systems may lead some to ignore how media environments can vary within similar political systems. Despite the impact that political systems have on media norms and routines, certain social, cultural, economic, historical, and technological factors can also influence how journalists construct news stories. It is important to also focus more directly on the influence that various media environments have on the construction of news and the many factors that contribute to these differences.

News Distortion Theories

The second set of building blocks for PMP comes from researchers who deal with the various ways in which the media turn political realities into a product known as news. Political communication scholars agree that no form of news can present a full and accurate view of the political world. One of the common themes of this body of research is that when politics is turned into news there is an

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inevitable distortion that can, at times, have a profound impact on the political process. One form of distortion that has received an especially significant amount of attention can be labeled "commercial bias" (Wolfsfeld, 2011). This term refers to all of the ways in which journalists collect and package information with the goal of attracting as large an audience as possible. While there are many other ways in which journalists transform political realities, this particular line of research provides a useful foundation for better understanding the PMP principles developed below.

A recurring theme of this literature is that journalists have a vested interest in make the news entertaining. This trend is commonly referred to as infotainment (Anderson, 2004; Brants, 1998; Delli, Carpini & Williams, 2001; Moy, Xenos, & Hess, 2005; Thussu, 2008). Some would argue that this emphasis turns the political world into something akin to a reality show. Drama is a key element in almost every news report and has an effect on every aspect of the news production process. This includes how journalists are assigned to different beats, what parts of a story are emphasized or underplayed, and the way the story is told. As with the other forms of commercial bias, the amount of sensationalism varies depending on the time, culture, and media. Understanding how such differences influence the role of the media in politics is another essential step for making progress in the field.

A related set of research talks about the ways in which the news media generally employ a "strategic frame" to cover politics (Cappella & Jamieson, 1997; 1996; De Vreese & Semetko, 2002; Hallin, 1992; Hollihan, 2010; Mutz, 1995; Patterson, 1994; Valentino, Beckmann, & Buhr, 2001). One of the most important works in this tradition was carried out by Cappella and Jamieson (1996, 1997) who wrote, among other things, about the degree to which news reports focused on winners and losers and tended to use the language of war, games, and competition. They argued that this emphasis led journalists to devote less attention to substantive issues, especially in election campaigns. Cappella and Jamieson further claimed that this emphasis led to a higher level of political cynicism among the general public. Norris (2000) vehemently opposed this view and provided evidence that, with some exceptions, those people who consumed

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the most news were actually the ones who exhibited the greatest level of trust and political participation.

Strategic framing is discussed further below. For now, it will suffice to make three points that emerge from this body of literature. First, the news media often cover political events in ways that give preference to style over substance. Second, such emphases can sometimes have an effect on publics and political processes. Third, the extent to which different media adopt strategic frames is likely to vary over time and circumstance.

The final set of literature that will be mentioned within this tradition of news distortion comes mostly from those who are interested in the role of the media in peace processes (Hacket, 2006; Hanitzsch, 2004; Lynch & McGoldrick, 2005; Sheafer & Dvir-Gvirsman, 2010; Wolfsfeld, 2004; Wolfsfeld, Alimi & Kailani, 2007). The main theme that emerges from this literature is that conflict and violence is far more newsworthy than any attempts at peace and reconciliation. After all, conflict is the mainstay of news, and the bloodier the event, the more the story receives prominence. Because of this preference, leaders find it easier to mobilize the media for war than for peace.

One could make a similar point about the large amount of attention journalists give to violent crime. Societies that are in a constant state of fear are more likely to support calls for harsher penalties for criminals. Those who depend on the news media (especially sensationalist news media) for their view of reality live in a very frightening world. As with peace processes, stories about rehabilitation or other innovative policies for dealing with crime are less likely to receive attention in the news.

Interestingly, this particular form of news distortion has received far less attention among political communication scholars than the other forms mentioned above. However, the social and political consequences of such news routines may be even more significant than those associated with, say, the strategic coverage of election campaigns. Thinking about this form of commercial bias also has some theoretical advantages. While there are clearly some cross-cultural differences, an emphasis on conflict is universally considered more newsworthy than any form of cooperation. Therefore, the media's emphasis on

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conflict and violence has the potential to provide important evidence about how the news media can have an *independent* influence on the role of the media in politics above and beyond any influence that can be traced back to the effects of political context.

The Politics-Media-Politics Principle

It is worth reiterating the two central claims of the PMP principle, both of which build on the theories and approaches discussed earlier. The first claim is that the role of the media in political processes can best be understood as a cycle in which variations in the political environment lead to variations in media conduct that, in turn, lead to further variations in the political environment. Second, the media can play an independent role in political processes due to their ability to transform political realities into news stories that can at times have a significant impact on political outcomes.

The first claim is taken from political context theories by arguing that any understanding of the role of the media must always start by considering the surrounding political environment. The second claim is rooted in what has been termed the news distortion approach. Editorial preferences transform the political world in ways that serve journalists' professional interests. The second assertion also points to the fact that these transformations can sometimes have significant influences on the political process.

Despite this theoretical debt to previous work, the PMP principle also has unique features that are designed to move the discussion forward. First, by referring to the PMP process as an ongoing cycle, it reminds us to look not only at how the media reacts and transforms what is happening in the political environment, but also whether any of this had a significant impact on the political world. In connection to this, the PMP principle emphasizes the need to focus on political *processes*. The role of the media can only be fully understood by thinking about changes that take place over time. This is true of wars, international relations, peace processes, policy processes, election campaigns, and ongoing debates over public issues. The political world is in constant flux and the amount and type of influence the media have on such processes varies depending on the time and circumstance.

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The discussion will be presented in two parts. The first section will provide the underlying logic and some supporting evidence for the claim that politics comes first and that any media influence should be considered a subsequent effect. The second part will talk about the ways in which the media transform political events into news and how this can sometimes have an impact on political processes. The final section will talk about some possible exceptions to the PMP principle.

Politics Comes First

The first part of the PMP principle emphasizes that anyone wanting to understand the role of the media in any political process should start by considering the political environment in which they are operating. The political environment can be defined as the aggregate of individual and collective beliefs, discourse, and behaviors concerning political matters within a particular setting and time. It is a "macro" concept that refers to the political "situation" writ large; this echoes what Iyengar and Kinder (1987) called "the tenor of the times". When thinking about the impact of the political environment on news coverage, it is helpful to consider both long-term changes (such as the end of the Cold War) and short-term changes (for example, a dispute between Russia and the United States over how to deal with a particular conflict).

A good place to start the discussion about changes in the political climate is with how the coverage of major social issues changes over time. For example, consider the way media coverage is influenced by the changes in how the media frame issues related to race, gender, and homosexuality (Avraham, Wolfsfeld, & Aburaiya, 2000; Avraham, 2003; Byerly, 2008; Kane, 1988; First & Avraham, 2003; Freeman, 2001; Terkildsen & Damore, 1999). Western journalists did not simply wake up one morning and change their coverage of these topics. In each of these cases, early activists faced significant challenges in gaining sympathetic news coverage. As the political climate changed, journalists became increasingly willing to accept the legitimacy of these groups and news frames began to change.

At least three mechanisms explain how and why the news media reflect such changes in the political climate. The first is that a growing number of their elite sources begin to relate to these issues differently. For example, consider again

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issues related to equality and human rights. An increasing willingness of the more liberal politicians, social activists, and other opinion leaders to openly support such causes has meant that more progressive views have appeared more often in news coverage (Entman, 2004; Froehlich & Rudiger, 2006; Hallin, 1989; Hanggli, 2012, Kim & Seo, 2009; Kim et. al., 2010; Scheufele, 2000).[1] A second mechanism is that journalists themselves are important targets for such movements and many also become convinced of the righteousness of a cause. A third explanation is related to audiences. Reporters and editors are always sensitive to the attitudes and prejudices of their audiences (see, for example, Chong & Druckman, 2007). Writing a story in favor of gay marriage in the 1970s would have led to very different public reactions than one written today.

Changes in the climate of opinion also have an impact on the entertainment media (Williams & Delli Carpini, 2011, Franklin, 2006). Here too, most investors, producers, and advertisers must consider the sensitivities of their potential audience. This is especially likely to be the case with fictional prime-time television programs. Writers and producers of such stories may sometimes be slightly "ahead of the curve" on these types of issues, but their willingness to create programs that include, for example, gay-sympathetic characters is clearly related to the overall climate of opinion.

Another way to think about this process is by returning to the notion of news frames (Chong & Druckman, 2007; Entman, 2007; Scheufele & Tewksbury, 2007). As the political environment surrounding a particular issue changes, the news media often move away from employing a single dominant news frame and begin to relate to the issue as contested or controversial. Two or more competing frames emerge, which can have a dramatic impact on news coverage. Gamson and Modigliani (1989) provided an excellent demonstration of this process in their research on changing media frames of nuclear power in the United States. In the early years after World War II, nuclear energy was seen an extremely positive light; there were almost no negative stories about nuclear reactors. Gamson and Modigliani (1989) labeled this positive media frame as "Progress". They argued that the lack of alternative perspectives helps to explain why a 1966 nuclear accident at the Fermi reactor in Michigan received very little media

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attention. The *New York Times* took five weeks to report on the story and then referred to it as a mere "mishap".

The political climate began to change in the 1970s, in part because of the growing influence of the anti-nuclear movement. At that point, there were *competing* frames about nuclear power, including one that Gamson and Modigliani referred to as "Runaway": the claim that nuclear technology was spinning out of control and could lead to disaster. An important turning point occurred in 1979 with a partial nuclear meltdown at the Three Mile Island plant in Pennsylvania. Unlike what happened in Fermi, this accident received a great deal of publicity and the "Runaway" frame started to dominate media discourse. Political change (a growing concern among certain elites about the dangers of nuclear power) had led to media change (different news frames for dealing with the issue). It is also reasonable to assume that the increasing media emphasis on the dangers of nuclear power contributed to policy changes, as many states decided to halt the construction of nuclear plants. If so, this subsequent influence on government policy would be an ideal example of the next (but not necessarily final) stage in a PMP cycle.

The example of nuclear energy also highlights the fact that, when talking about changes in media performance, it is important to look at the entertainment media. In a bizarre coincidence, the movie "The China Syndrome" was released 12 days before the accident at Three Mile Island. On the other hand, it wasn't really a complete coincidence. Both types of media were reacting simultaneously to the changing political environment surrounding nuclear energy.

One of the best examples of a PMP cycle comes from the rich and meticulous study of Baumgartner, De Boef, and Boydstun (2008) about the reframing of the death penalty the United States. Their underlying claim is that those opposed to the death penalty were able to introduce a powerful new argument to public discourse known as the "innocence" frame. The innocence frame promotes the idea that the state must stop using the death penalty because guiltless people are being put to death. Although it took a considerable amount of time, the ability of activists to promote this frame to the media had a dramatic effect on how the death penalty controversy was framed in the news.

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The death penalty has always been controversial in the United States. For years, many of the arguments surrounding the debate centered on questions of constitutionality, morality, and deterrence. The rise of the new frame started with a dedicated group of legal aid innocence projects in Chicago and New York in the 1980s. The projects were dedicated to exonerate innocent prisoners who found themselves on death row. Developments in DNA research were certainly among the changes that made it easier to have these individuals acquitted. Nonetheless, the researchers found that the shift in public attention towards the question of innocence took a full decade. In keeping with the PMP principle, the shift only occurred "after a nexus of political forces pushed it in that direction" (Baumgartner, De Boef, and Boydstun, 2008, p. 51).

Baumgartner et al. made it clear that the changes in news attention and frames were a critical element in this process. Their extensive content analysis of media coverage shows that after a rapid rise in the innocence frame during the 1990s, this frame had come to "dominate the debate" (p. 137). One of the consequences of this change is that exonerated prisoners had become much more newsworthy. While the number of exonerees also increased somewhat during the 1990s – from an average of three per year to seven – the yearly average of news stories increased 24-fold. In 2005 (the last year for which the researchers collected data), "the average number of stories an individual exonerated from death row is likely to get is thirteen times the number that someone exonerated in the pre-innocence frame could expect" (p. 97). As the authors put it: "Something changed and it was not the facts. Exonerees are simply more newsworthy today than before the innocence movement began" (p. 97).

The authors then showed that the increasing salience of the innocence frame in the media had a major impact on public opinion and public policies. While there were also other forces at work (for example, a declining homicide rate), the authors convincingly demonstrated that the change in media coverage also contributed to this change. This latter effect supports the *subsequent* influence of media coverage on the political environment: "variations in media conduct lead to further variations in the political environment". The change began with political activists working to change opinions and policy; the media then picked

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up on this changing climate and made their own contribution by emphasizing the new frame.

All of this is reminiscent of what happened in the reframing of the controversy over nuclear energy. As the "Runaway" frame gained prominence, stories about nuclear mishaps became more newsworthy, which provided more ammunition for the anti-nuclear movements. Such changes in news frames carve out new space and time for certain types of stories, which, in turn, has an influence on public discourse and, at least in some cases, on public policy.

While Baumgartner et al. (2008) had no knowledge of the PMP principle, their summary provides an ideal demonstration of its validity. They concluded that the activities of the innocence movement led to a "shift in the focus of the death penalty debate … The consequence of these events and media framing … is fundamentally but slowly to alter public opinion as well as public policy" (p. 214).

The PMP principle and the Role of the Media in War and Peace

The PMP principle can also help us better understand the role of the media in the course of wars and peace processes. One of the most consistent findings in this set of literature has to do with the relationship between elite consensus in support of a war and media frames of war (Bennett, 1990; Bennett, Lawrence and Livingston, 2007; Entman, 2003; Hallin, 1989; Mermin, 1999; Robinson, 2001; Wolfsfeld, 1997). The first major research on this topic was Hallin's (1987) study of the role of the media in the Vietnam War. Contrary to the popular wisdom, the U.S. press was extremely supportive of the war in its early stages. Those who opposed the war were considered radicals and given the dominance of the "Cold War" frame, it would have been surprising if the American media had adopted a different position.

So what changed? Because Vietnam was the first televised war, it is understandable that many early commentators attributed the declining support for the war to the new technology.[2] However, Hallin argued that the American media were actually reacting to changes in elite consensus. As the war dragged on, an increasing number of "legitimate" sources started to raise questions as to whether the war could be won. As Hallin described it, the issue of the Vietnam War moved from the "sphere of consensus" to the "sphere of legitimate

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controversy". A telling sign that an issue has become controversial is when current affairs programs feel the need to invite different "sides" to debate about an issue.

Wolfsfeld (1997) reached a similar conclusion about the impact that varying consensuses have on the media coverage of wars. One of the interesting characteristics of the 1991 Gulf War was that, unlike most conflicts, national consensus in support of the war actually *increased*. This shows that changes in political environments do not all move in the same direction. In the period leading up to the war, President George Bush had considerable trouble convincing the Senate to approve his decision to use military force in response to Saddam Hussein's invasion of Kuwait. The news media reflected these difficulties. Entman and Page's (1994) study found that 55 percent of editorials in the *New York Times* and the *Washington Post* were critical of the Bush policy and 45 percent were supportive.

It is important to stress the critical role that political elites play in this process as privileged sources. Once the Gulf War broke out, journalists were certainly interested in talking to political leaders who had opposed the military intervention. However, once American troops had been put in harm's way and it seemed the operation would be a success, it was almost impossible to find leaders who were willing to go on record against the war (Wolfsfeld, 1997).

A similar point could be made about the role of the media in the Iraq War that began in 2000. The main thesis in Bennett, Lawrence, and Livingston's book on this topic, entitled *When the Press Fails* (2007), is that the American press failed to uncover the many failures associated with the war because journalists were too dependent on official sources. The authors argue that journalists should have paid more attention to other credible sources and not be so blinded by power. However, it is noteworthy that Democratic opposition leaders waited for a considerable amount of time before speaking out against the war (Wolfsfeld, 2008). It is clear to even the most casual observer that once Democratic leaders did take a stand against the war, this issue also entered "the sphere of legitimate controversy". Indeed, it became a major rallying point in Barack Obama's 2008 election campaign.

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Wolfsfeld's (2004) research into the role of the media in peace processes also provides important evidence in support of PMP. That study examined the role of the media in three conflicts: the Oslo peace process between Israel and the Palestinians, the Israeli-Jordanian peace process, and the peace process in Northern Ireland that culminated in the 1998 Good Friday Agreement. Wolfsfeld argued that the idea of "variations in the political environment" is no longer limited to changes that take place over time. It refers to variations in the amount of support for different policy issues (comparing the Olso and Jordanian peace processes) and to cross-cultural variations (comparing what happened in Israel to what happened in Northern Ireland). However, the central claim remains the same: variations in the political environment are linked to variations in media performance, which lead to further variations in the political environments.

While the Olso peace process was extremely controversial in Israel, the other two peace processes enjoyed strong support. Thus, while the agreement with the Palestinians barely received a majority in the Knesset, the agreement with Jordan received overwhelming support. Support for the Good Friday agreement was also very high, as indicated by votes in the Northern Ireland Assembly and in the referendum held after the signing of the accord (Wolfsfeld, 2004). In all three cases, these differences in the political environments reflected and reinforced local media frames of the different processes. The local media enthusiastically supported the Jordanian and Northern Ireland peace processes, while coverage of Oslo was far more mixed.

There is also evidence that these differences in media coverage of the various peace processes had a subsequent impact on the political environments. This evidence will be presented in a later discussion, which also considers the impact of the differences in the media environments.

Political Environments, the Media, and Election Campaigns

The significant influence that changing political environments have on the role of the media can also be understood by looking at research on election campaigns. There are two reasons why this additional evidence is important. First, in contrast to the previous examples, it deals with the way in which more short-term changes in political environments can have an impact on media

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coverage. Second, it enables us to explore an area in which political actors appear to be especially weak and vulnerable when they find themselves adapting the demands of the media.

A useful place to demonstrate the underlying logic of PMP would be to look at the research concerning priming (Balmas & Shefer, 2010; Druckman, 2004; Kelleher & Wolak, 2006; Scheufele, 2007; Sheafer 2005, 2007). The priming effect is usually seen as a "media effect" in which issues that are emphasized in the news media become a major yardstick when voters are evaluating different candidates. However, this formulation gives too much credit to the media and not enough to what is occurring in the surrounding environment.[3] An editorial decision to emphasize a certain issue during an election campaign is likely to come from one of two possible sources. First, it can come from a dramatic set of events such as an economic crisis or a terrorist attack. Therefore, it was hardly a coincidence that, after the 2008 economic crisis, the question of how to rescue the economy became a major issue in that year's presidential campaign. Second, the news agenda can come from a successful promotional effort by one of the campaigns. Two examples a George H.W. Bush's success in promoting the idea in 1988 that Michael Dukakis was "soft on crime" (Ansolabehere & Iyengar, 2010; Mendelberg, 1997) and the Swift Boat ads used against John Kerry in the 2004 campaign (Campbell, 2005; Tomas, 2004). Here too, however, the initiatives came not from the journalists, but from the candidates and their advisors. In addition, campaign decisions to emphasize certain issues are always based on an assessment of what will resonate with voters at that particular time.

The major point to take away from the discussion thus far is that any attempt to understand the role of the media in politics must start by considering the surrounding political environment. This becomes especially true when thinking about political change concerning major public issues, including the conduct of wars and peace processes. There seems to be little evidence or logic to suggest that any of the significant changes discussed above were initiated by the media. The same can be said about the decisions made by political candidates who employ strategies and tactics that resonate with particular publics at a particular

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time and place. Although there are exceptions, the most important effects of the media, it is argued, take place after they *react* to political actions and events.

The Transformative Power of the Media

The discussion now turns to the second major component of the Politics-Media-Politics principle: *The media can have an independent impact on political processes due to their ability to transform political realities into news stories*. This part of the argument claims that despite everything discussed above, the news media *can* have an independent effect on political processes. Although such effects never take place in a political vacuum, they are certainly worthy of study and analysis.

It is important to begin by stating that the independent impact of the media on a given political process varies with time and circumstances (Wolfsfeld, 1997). There are certainly political processes in which the news media play a significant role in the final outcome. In other processes, either the level of distortion is relatively trivial or the overall impact of the news stories on politics is insignificant. Research in this field should attempt to reveal the circumstances that move the news media along this theoretical continuum.

It is also important to emphasize the problems inherent in talking about "the media". For example, some news organs are clearly more sensationalist (Esser, 1999; Semetko & Valkenberg, 2000; Zelizer, 2009) and more influential (Druckman, 2005; Golan, 2006) than others. Any serious analysis would require researchers to examine *which* news media are especially important in each context, both in terms of their circulation and their potential impact on elites.

One solution to this problem is to ask about the nature of the *media environment* in a particular time and place. The notion of a media environment refers to the aggregate of professional beliefs, values, and routines that journalists employ in the construction of news stories (Wolfsfeld, 2004). These definitions vary over time and culture, which is one reason why the role of the news media in political processes also varies (Strömbäck & Dimitrova, 2011). In a more sensationalist media environment, entertainment values will play a larger role in the selection of news stories and in the way such stories are told.

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For example, De Vreese (2005) examined news coverage in Denmark and the Netherlands of a European Union Summit that took place in December of 2002. He used content analysis to confirm that the Dutch press was significantly more likely than the Danish press to use a strategic frame to cover the conference. In the Netherlands, greater exposure to the news media led to an *increase* in political cynicism, while greater exposure to the Danish coverage of the summit led to a *decrease* in political cynicism. This illustrates why it is important for researchers to look at variations in the media environments as well as in political environments.

The ways in which the nature of the media environment can have an impact on media coverage can also be shown by looking at the cross-national research on election coverage. A good example of this is Strömbäck and Dimitrova's (2011) study, which compared journalistic norms for covering elections in Sweden and the United States. The two media systems are very different, largely because of the relative strength of public broadcasting in Sweden compared to the U.S. Among other things, this has led to significantly more use of a strategic game frame in U.S. election coverage.

Although Strömbäck and Dimitrova did not deal with this aspect, there is evidence that such differences can have a subsequent impact on voters (the second part of the PMP cycle). Ellenbaas and De Vreese (2008) looked at the effects of strategic framing on cynicism and on voting; specifically, at media coverage of a referendum on European integration. They found that the greater the degree to which people were exposed to news outlets using a strategic frame, the higher the level of political cynicism and the likelihood that such individuals would vote "No". Taken together, these studies all show that editorial decisions to use a strategic frame can have an impact on political processes.

Media and Peace

An additional demonstration of the second claim of the PMP principle can be found by returning to the varying role of the news media in the peace processes that were discussed earlier (Wolfsfeld, 2004). It was stated that the nature of the political environments were critical in determining how the domestic media dealt with the Oslo peace process, with the peace process between Israel and Jordan,

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and in Northern Ireland. However, another important component that contributed to role that each country's media played was the very different *media environments* in Israel and Northern Ireland.

Two differences in the media environments contributed to the Northern Ireland press playing a more constructive role in the Good Friday process. The first was that the media environment in Northern Ireland is much less sensationalist than that in Israel (Wolfsfeld, 2004). For example, the sensationalist nature of the Israeli media ensured that many threats issued by right-wing extremists received front page coverage. The coverage of terrorist attacks during the Oslo peace process was nothing short of hysterical. However, the Northern Ireland media environment was much less sensationalist. In fact, journalists who were interviewed talked about the steps they were taking to avoid the dangers associated with sensationalist coverage. One example was a decision by television crews not to send cameras crews to cover minor incidents of violence in order to avoid the risk of inflaming the situation.

Sheafer and Dvir-Vrisman (2010) conducted a long-term analysis of the impact of the media coverage on public opinion while *controlling for the influence of real life events*. That study provides even more convincing evidence that the sensationalist media environment in Israel had a detrimental effect on the Oslo process and confirmed Wolfsfeld's findings that the negativity of the Israeli press went beyond what might have been expected if the media were merely reacting to what was happening on the ground. Perhaps even more significant and problematic was Sheafer and Dvir-Vrisman's findings about the impact of this emphasis on public opinion about Oslo. The impact of negatively framed stories was significantly more powerful than stories that used more positive frames for the process.

This evidence is important because it provides a powerful demonstration of the second claim of the PMP principle. The Israeli media were shown to have an *independent* impact on Israeli public opinion, which can be directly linked to the transformation of the political realities associated with Oslo. There was plenty of negative news to report, but the editorial decision to emphasize on this aspect also played a role in what happened.

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Another difference between the media environments in Israel and Northern Ireland also had an impact on the two peace processes. Much of the press in Northern Ireland is "shared" between Protestants and Catholics (Wolfsfeld, 2004). This is especially true of the television and radio stations, which employ journalists from both sides of the conflict and broadcast to the entire population. It is even true of the "Protestant" and "Catholic" newspapers in Northern Ireland. All of the newspapers employ people from both sides of the divide and attempt to attract both Protestant and Catholic readers. The media environments in Israel and Palestine are more typical of what one finds in most conflicts. Most Jewish Israelis get their news from the Hebrew news media and Palestinians mostly from their own media and other Arabic sources such as Al-Jazeera.

Wolfsfeld (2004) argued that these differences in the level of shared media also had important effects on the varying roles of the media in the two processes. Interviews with Northern Ireland journalists revealed that they were acutely conscious of the fact that their audience included both Protestants and Catholics and they had to use language that both communities could accept. There was also a great deal of active cooperation between newspapers from either side of the divide. This included editorials written by editors from the competing newspapers and the initiation of joint petitions against violence.

The overall conclusion was that these differences in professional norms also contributed to the impact of the two sets of media. In Northern Ireland, both Protestants and Catholics were provided with an ongoing flow of non-threatening news that increased the chances for reconciliation between the antagonists. In Israel and among the Palestinians, each of the antagonists was constantly exposed to the more typical flow of ethnocentric stories, which reinforced mutual suspicion and hatred. Here too, the differences in the two media environments help explain the different norms for covering the processes, as well as the likely impact of the coverage on each population.

The role that the Israeli news media played in the Jordanian peace process reminds us that, despite the potential impact of the media environment, it is important to *start* by considering the overall political context. As discussed, the peace process between Jordan and Israel was relatively cordial and violence-free.

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The sensationalism of the Israel press was not a major factor because there was simply little negative news to report.

As a metaphor, consider the effects that wind has on a forest fire. When there is no fire, the state of the wind is irrelevant. When a fire breaks out, however, the wind can have a critical influence on the intensity, direction, and amount of damage the fire can bring. The same can be said about the influence that a sensationalist news media has on a peace process. When there is little or no violence associated with a peace process, as in the negotiations with Jordan, the relative sensationalism of the Israeli media environment is not a problem. Some would argue that it was even good for peace because it increased the excitement associated with the peace accords when they were finally signed. In contrast, the sensationalism associated with the Oslo process increased the conflict within Israel.

A similar point can be made about the relationship between the political and media environments in the context of the Northern Ireland example. Many attempts had been made to bring peace to the region, including what was known as the Anglo-Irish agreement of 1995. The Protestant community was firmly against that pact and many felt it constituted a surrender by the British government. Neither the lack of sensationalism nor the fact that there was a shared media made much of a difference. The Protestant spokespeople and the Protestant media made it clear that their lack of support for the agreement would prevent progress. Once again, the negative political environment proved more important than the potentially helpful media environment.

Distinguishing Between Framing and Infotainment

A final theoretical distinction concerning media effects is important. One could legitimately ask about the difference between the impact that media frames have on political processes compared to transformations designed to make the story more interesting. Why should framing be considered a political effect while the emphasis on drama and negativity is considered a media effect? In both cases, journalists shape the story in ways that resonate with their audience.

The reason for this distinction is that, in most cases, the interpretive frames employed by journalists are rooted in the surrounding political environment.[4]

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This was the underlying theme of much of the initial discussion concerning the role of the media in political change. It is also a major focus for those who see news as a social construction (Adoni & Mane, 1984; Gamson, et al., 1992; Carragee & Roefs 2006, Van Gorp, 2007). Media frames generally reflect current thinking on political issues and when views change, so do news frames. On the other hand, the emphasis on drama and entertainment comes from the journalists' own needs to increase audience size. Journalists tell stories in this way because it is the only way they can remain profitable. Therefore, if and when such transformations have an impact on a political process, it should be seen as a case in which the media have made their own independent contribution to the outcome.[5]

In sum, the PMP principle acknowledges that the news media's power to transform political realities enables them to have a significant impact on political processes. Nevertheless, both the inputs that are being processed by the media and the nature of any subsequent impact of the news stories are still closely linked to the surrounding political environment.

Some Important Exceptions to the PMP principle

There are certain exceptions to PMP, consideration of which can help refine and improve the model. While it is not possible to provide a comprehensive list, it will be useful to consider two major categories of exceptions. The first are exceptions in which the weight of media transformations appears far more significant than the initial political component. The second set of exceptions comprises those relatively rare cases in which the media independently *initiate* news stories that have significant effects on political processes.

One way for the news media to have a disproportionate influence on a political process is to devote a large amount of attention to a relatively trivial political event. Two examples involve individuals with no social or political standing deciding to carry out acts that angered large Muslim populations. The first was when Florida pastor Terry Jones burned a Koran in March of 2011. He made a point of filming the event and it was claimed that the subsequent video led to rioting and a number of deaths in Afghanistan.[6] The second incident occurred in the fall of 2012 when a short video entitled "The Innocence of

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Muslims" was produced. Although it was originally released in July of that year, an explosion in violence took place when the Egyptian media began showing it on air and dubbed versions began to appear on the Internet.[7]

It could be argued that these events had no inherent political importance. On any given news day, there are thousands of extremist groups around the world looking for media attention; they only become politically significant when journalists decide to cover them. One way to represent this type of process in relation to the more general principle is to use a small p and a capital M (pMP).

These are perhaps extreme examples and deciding which events are *inherently* politically significant is not always straight forward. Consider, for example, the embarrassing 2012 video of Governor Mitt Romney speaking to Republican fundraisers with seeming contempt about the "forty-seven percent" of Americans who pay no income tax and are "dependent on government".[8] It is doubtful that without extensive media attention this would not have become a campaign issue. Nevertheless, this took place at a political event initiated by a serious presidential candidate and his remarks were considered scandalous. Therefore, that particular event can be seen as consistent with the PMP principle.

Thinking about the amount of editorial discretion provides a possible solution to this analytical dilemma. Compare the anti-Muslim events described earlier with the remarks by Governor Romney. In the first case, the media could have easily passed over these events and not turned them into news stories. As noted, few such extremist events are ever recorded by the international news media. Motivated journalists are just a click or two away from finding an endless reservoir of racist comments and speeches. In the case of Romney's remarks, on the other hand, any news editor would consider such controversial comments from a serious presidential candidate to be a legitimate news story. This type of approach uses an experimental logic to assess the relative weights that should be assigned to the initial political event and the subsequent coverage.

The second category of exceptions covers those cases in which the media *initiates* a political news story that has a significant impact on a political process. The most obvious examples of this phenomenon take place in the case of investigative journalism. Here too, the decision about how much weight to give to

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the journalists' efforts is unlikely to be simple. Many such stories are initiated by political actors attempting to embarrass their rivals, which indicates that politics is still the priority. For example, in the Watergate scandal, "Deep Throat" (Mark Felt) continually supplied the journalist Bob Woodward with essential information for the news story (Felt & O'Conner, 2006; Holland, 2012).

Nevertheless, there are certainly investigative stories for which the primary initiators are journalists tracking down leads to uncover government corruption. In the context of American journalism, such examples can be found in the list of journalists who have received Pulitzer Prizes for investigative journalism. In 2009, for example, David Barstow of the *New York Times* revealed that some retired generals had been co-opted by the Pentagon to promote their positions on the war in Iraq (Barstow & Stein, 2005). Assuming that the uncovering of such scandals has some political fallout (in this case, for the news media and the Pentagon), this group of exceptions can be abbreviated as MPMP.

These two sets of exceptions to the PMP principle are based on very different ideas. In the first set of cases (pMP), the unusually large influence attributed to the news media comes from the fact that the *transformation* of the political events seems is more significant than the initial occurrence. The second group of exceptions (MPMP) is rooted in the fact that media actions *precede* any political events. In the first group, the exceptions are related to the relative weight we should attribute to the political and media factors, while the second set of exceptions refers to the issue of chronology.

Thinking about these exceptions returns us to the previous discussion suggesting that the actual role of the media in a given political process varies along a continuum of influence. Even when the PMP principle makes perfect sense, one would still want to raise questions as to whether the initial event (or events), the media coverage of the event, or the particular way the media transformed the event had any significant impact on the political process. Although it is difficult to definitively answer these questions, they always need to be asked.

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Summary and Research Agenda

The Politics-Media-Politics principle is intended to provide a basis for developing a more comprehensive approach to the role of the media in political processes. It has the potential to meet the various conditions outlined in the introduction to this paper. The focus on both political and media environments will help us better integrate these two sets of variables. Thinking about varying political environments should help understand how the role of the media changes across time and cultures. Finally, as demonstrated above, PMP can be applied to a wide range of different topics including the role of the media in election campaigns, changing views and policies about controversial issues, and the role of the media in wars and peace processes.

The road forward is fairly clear, although it will involve an uphill climb and many conceptual and empirical obstacles. The first task is to examine how the PMP principle can be applied and adapted to explain the role of the *new media* in political processes. While some aspects can be applied fairly easily, others will need to be modified in order to make the transition from old to new. A second undertaking involves trying to better define the types of political and media variables that seem especially critical for explaining each stage in the PMP process. Third, we need to provide more details about how and when the weight attributed to the news media is likely to rise and fall. Finally, an effort must be made to more fully understand the exceptions to the PMP principle and whether the model can be further developed in order to minimize such exceptions. Therefore, although a great deal of work remains to be done, it is hoped that at least some of the ideas presented here will convince others that this path is worth pursuing.

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Notes

[1] The study of these processes is often referred to as "frame building". See, for example, Hanggli (2012) and Zhou & Moy (2007).

[2] Some would argue that those who overemphasize the role of the new media in political conflicts are making a similar mistake (Wolfsfeld, Segev, and Sheafer, 2013).

[3] Another scholar who has problems with the usual assumptions about the priming effect is Gabriel Lenz (2009). He provides convincing evidence that when researchers find priming effects they are ignoring the fact that people may be simply *learning* more about the parties' or candidates' positions and then adapting their preferred party's or candidate's position as their own. If so, this suggests that the politicians are using the media to *inform* voters, which is consistent with the PMP approach in that claims about "independent" media effects are misleading.

[4] One type of framing that might be more difficult to classify in this regard is what might be referred to as "formatting frames". Perhaps the most well-known example is the distinction made by Iyengar and Kinder (1987) between "episodic" and "thematic frames". While episodic frames tell a story that focusses almost exclusively on a particular event, thematic frames place an issue within a more general context. While the decision by journalists to use a thematic frame is probably related to how popular a particular idea has become in a particular time and place, the use of episodic frames may be related to creating more interesting news stories.

[5] One could argue that there is a relationship between the nature of a particular society and the extent to which the media emphasize entertainment values. If this is true, it would suggest that such editorial decisions are not completely independent as suggested. However, an exploration of this idea is beyond the scope of this discussion.

[6] http://www.washingtonpost.com/local/education/florida-pastor-terry-joness-koran-burning-has-far-reaching-effect/2011/04/02/AFpiFoQC_story.html

[7] http://www.washingtonpost.com/blogs/under-god/post/anti-islam-film-stirs-outrage-as-violence-spreads/2012/09/13/c9972808-fdec-11e1-8adc-499661afe377_blog.html

[8] http://thecaucus.blogs.nytimes.com/2012/09/17/romney-faults-those-dependent-on-government/

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